

though. Some partnerships will be ineffective and some will be successful. One can't expect immediate, substantial changes. This is something that will improve over time. But we have not succeeded in deregulation because of an old mindset, and that needs to be controlled. It is only with a clear understanding of the kind of deregulation framework that a public-private partnership can begin and evolve. In some cases, there are no answers and we will find those only once we start the process.

There also needs to be generational change and not incremental change. There is a need to understand how children learn today as opposed to 20 years ago. There is a need to recognise the importance of using technology as the learning methods of the past are not

A new model: With Internet and the digital revolution, classrooms will change



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relevant anymore. When we think of education, we think of duster, chalk, blackboard, homework, exams and grades. But all these things don't have the same meaning anymore. I am beginning to question a lot of these things. And we need to realise that we can't have the same set of universities and school buildings of the past. That model of the university has not changed. The things we identified with a university—whether it's 500 acre of land, a big building or a library, all of these things are not relevant anymore. We need to realise that we can't keep building those same universities. With Internet and the digitisation of information, we need new models of universities, campuses and schools. We can't even have the same set of teachers anymore.

Teachers have traditionally been used to create and deliver content. Today, content has been created by the best of the best brains on the Internet and delivery could be possible through the electronic media. This doesn't

mean everyone has to have computers. And if that is the case, then teachers will have to change from that of creating and delivering content to that of a mentor. And so, teachers have to be completely retrained. Even content needs to be changed. Our graduates specialise too early. There is no focus on liberal arts. Everyone wants to be an engineer. That's why we can't have good leaders. A lot of these things have to change.

And it will take time. Everyone wants quick fixes. That is something we can't have. It will take 20 years to change things. Just like it happened in telecom. I knew it, but nobody believed it then. When you are trying to change society, it takes a long time and people have to realise this. The beginning, of course, is with a change in the mind of the people. We are trying to change a society and it will take a long time. People have to realise this fact. We need to keep talking about it, to hammer these facts into the minds of the people, to gain political will, to understand, to communicate and write about it. It's a whole process and not a product. Remember, this is a society of over a billion people.

We have had a good start with the National Knowledge Commission. To me, this was a historic event in the modern history of India. But I don't think people have noticed that. They have got lost in petty controversies. But the kind of attention this commission has got in the world is phenomenal. I was invited to deliver the keynote speech at the US Department of State in Washington D.C. And this was recognition given to the Knowledge Commission, and not Sam Pitroda. But in India, no one bothered to take note of this development. People are more interested in the Sam Pitroda-Arjun Singh controversy. They like to twist facts and make a mess. It's sad that we are built this way. No one talks about the commission's initiatives, in 30 areas. None of the Indian professors has even looked at its website. We are a country of 100 billion and the website has only had 5,000 hits, that too mostly from foreign countries. None of the professors has even read about the university reforms we suggested. They should be lobbying for the reforms, holding seminars, conferences and debates at a national level. There has to be a movement involving everyone to improve knowledge infrastructure in the country. Education is but one piece of the whole process. And it is only then that we will be able to build a new India.

Badly Hit

IN A COUNTRY OF OVER 100 BILLION, THE WEBSITE OF THE NATIONAL KNOWLEDGE COMMISSION HAS HAD ONLY 5,000 HITS, MOSTLY FROM ABROAD. DO THE STAKEHOLDERS CARE ABOUT INDIA?

The author is chairman of the National Knowledge Commission.